

SORROW, OUTRAGE FLARE AT HEARING

Residents of Palisades share testimony with senators on plight of seniors in wake of fire.

By Hailey Branson-Potts, Ana Ceballos and Hannah Fry

In an emotional congressional hearing punctuated by immense frustration, six Pacific Palisades residents on Thursday spoke of family memories lost, an inadequate city response and a burdensome rebuilding process after the deadly inferno that destroyed thousands of homes and killed 12 people.

The panel of residents urged the federal government to intervene in the process of rebuilding and release funds that would help accelerate restoration of their homes and provide necessary safety improvements to water systems, streets and utilities after January's Palisades fire.

"The pattern is clear: local government failed us on Jan. 7 and continues to fail us," said Jessica Rogers, president of the Pacific Palisades Resident Assn. and a geriatric social worker. "We've been forced to lead our own recovery because the city won't."

The public hearing — held at an American Legion hall across the street from the burned husk of the private, elementary Village School — was the first after Republican Sens. Rick Scott of Florida and Ron Johnson of Wisconsin's announcement in September that they would lead an inquiry into the fire.

The investigation, they said, is necessary to "uncover and expose the truth" about how the state and local governments responded to the inferno, which broke out amid hurricane-force winds and quickly overwhelmed firefighting resources.

Some local officials, such as Los Angeles City Councilmember Hugo Soto-Martínez, have characterized the inquiry as a "witch hunt" by "MAGA" [See Palisades, A12]



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

L.A. COUNTY worker Pablo Castellano, top, helps prepare sand bags Thursday as Altadena residents line up to get them. In Malibu, a worker crosses Topanga Canyon Boulevard last month. The road was closed due to possible mudslides.

Storm forecast intensifies; flooding, mudflows possible

Evacuation warnings were slated for L.A. County as inclement weather approached.

By Rong-Gong Lin II and Clara Harter

Evacuation warnings were set to go into effect across Los Angeles County on Thursday evening as an atmospheric river approached Southern California, bringing with it the potential to put an early end to fire season while also bringing fresh risks of flooding and mudslides.

Under the storm scenario deemed most likely by fore-

casters, downtown L.A. would see 2.62 inches of rain Friday morning through Sunday, according to the National Weather Service. That could be enough to flood roads, swell rivers and creeks and cause minor shallow debris flows.

Rain of that extent would also make this L.A.'s wettest November in 40 years. And there's a 30% chance of even higher precipitation — 4.81 inches over the same time period for downtown L.A.

That would raise the possibility of significant mud and debris flows, as well as localized flooding of homes and businesses.

There's also a 10% chance that just about 1.4 inches of rain could fall downtown,

which would result in only minor problems.

The day of highest risk is Saturday. For that day, "the main message is that there's still a pretty substantial potential for heavy rain over parts of our area, with a reasonable risk for flash flooding and debris flows," said Ryan Kittell, a meteorologist with the National Weather Service office in Oxnard. Debris flows are a type of landslide in which rainfall combines with mud and debris to move with destructive potential off hillsides.

However, as far as fire season is concerned, "this will certainly help," Kittell said.

[See Storm, A8]

Ex-aide's fraud case unsettles Newsom's orbit

Allegations against former chief of staff involve work she did in the private sector.

By Kevin Rector, Sonja Sharp, Melody Gutierrez and Jessica Garrison

As Gov. Gavin Newsom flew around the country last year campaigning for President Biden and Vice President Kamala Harris, his chief of staff, Dana Williamson — known as one of California's toughest political insiders — was not only helping to helm the ship in Sacramento but also under criminal investigation by federal law enforcement.

The resulting criminal case, which splashed into public view with Williamson's arrest Wednesday, does not implicate Newsom in any wrongdoing. Williamson's alleged misdeeds occurred in private work before her joining his staff, and his office said it placed her on leave in November 2024 after she informed him she was under investigation.

Nonetheless, the allegations struck at the center of the political power circle surrounding Newsom, rattling one of the nation's most prominent and important hubs of Democratic state power at a time when President Trump and his Republican administration wield power in Washington.

Williamson was charged with bank and tax fraud for

allegedly siphoning campaign and COVID-19 recovery funds into her and an associate's pockets and claiming personal luxuries as business expenses on tax forms. According to the indictment, the campaign funds were drawn from a dormant state account of another top California Democrat: gubernatorial candidate and former U.S. Health and Human Services Secretary Xavier Becerra.

Two other well-connected aides in state politics were also charged — and struck plea deals confirming the scheme — while a third, with deep ties to one of the most well-connected circles of political and business consultants in the country, appeared in charging documents as an uncharged co-conspirator.

Williamson's attorney, McGregor Scott, a former U.S. attorney in Sacramento, told The Times on Wednesday that federal authorities had approached Williamson more than a year ago seeking help with some kind of investigation of the governor himself.

"She told them she had no information to provide them, and then we wind up today with these charges," Scott said. The nature of that alleged probe is unclear.

Newsom's office on Thursday said it was "not aware of any federal investigation involving the governor."

Lauren Horwood, a spokesperson for the U.S. attorney's office in Sacramento, said [See Aides, A7]

ANALYSIS

Epstein debacle grows for Trump

GOP lawmakers join effort to compel the release of all Justice Dept. files in inquiry.

By Michael Wilner and Ana Ceballos

WASHINGTON — A slow drip of revelations detailing President Trump's ties to Jeffrey Epstein that has burdened the White House all year has turned into a deluge after House lawmakers released reams of documents that imply the president may have intimate knowledge of his friend's criminal activity.

The scope of Epstein's interest in Trump became clear Thursday as media organizations combed

through more than 20,000 documents from the convicted sex offender's estate released by the House Oversight Committee, prompting a bipartisan majority in the House — including up to half of Republican lawmakers — to pledge support for a measure to compel the Justice Department to release all files related to its investigation of Epstein.

In one email discovered Thursday, sent by Epstein to himself months before he died by suicide in federal custody, he wrote: "Trump knew." The White House has denied that Trump knew about or was involved in Epstein's years-long operation that abused over 200 women and girls.

The scandal comes at a precarious political moment [See Scandal, A6]

Catholic bishops stand with migrants

By Ruben Vives

For the first time in 12 years, U.S. Catholic bishops have issued a unified statement to support the country's immigrants and oppose the Trump administration's "indiscriminate mass deportations of people."

The move marked a voice of support for immigrants — long a vital part of the U.S. Catholic Church — amid a year of unprecedented upheaval. It also continues a long tradition of the church as an institution of support for those in the country illegally that dates to the mas-



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

UNIONS AND immigrant rights groups rally in Los Angeles in October against federal immigration raids.

sive immigration sweeps in Los Angeles in the 1980s.

The special statement was issued Wednesday during the annual United States Conference of Catholic Bishops gathering in Baltimore. It was the first time since 2013 that the bishops had collectively voiced their concerns over an issue. The last time they did so was in response to the federal government's contraceptive mandate.

To show the consensus of the body, the bishops must vote to approve the special message, which was overwhelmingly supported with [See Bishops, A6]

Graduation rates soar faster than learning

State officials on Thursday celebrated new heights in just-released high school graduation rates, though similar achievement levels were not seen in other measures of student learning.

California's graduation rate of 87.5% is the highest since the launch of the state's current accountability dashboard in 2017. That rate is up 4.5 percentage points since 2017 and 11 percentage points from last year.

Groups that were behind generally improved more than those that were already doing well. This narrowed the gap separating those with the highest graduation rates — Asians and whites — from other groups, including Latino students, Black students and those in fos-

The gains don't necessarily reflect high schoolers' readiness for college or jobs

By Howard Blume

ter care. The rate for white students declined slightly but was essentially flat.

Although Gov. Gavin Newsom — and other state officials — positioned the results as a strong positive, Newsom's statement was measured.

"The more we can invest time, energy, and resources into our kids, the better their future can be," Newsom said. "Whether that future consists of college or jumping right into our state's workforce, we are going to continue our shared commitment to ensuring students and educators have the resources they need to be successful and pursue their California Dream."

Nationwide, the pendulum has shifted [See Graduation, A8]



GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

OHTANI WINS MVP

The Dodgers superstar, shown circling the bases after homering in the World Series, claims his fourth most valuable player award. **SPORTS, B10**

States scramble to send benefits

With shutdown over, officials say the delivery of full SNAP assistance to millions is being expedited. **NATION, A4**

Weather

Cooler with rain. L.A. Basin: 64/60. **B6**

Business **A10**
Opinion Voices **A13**

Handling of fire claims is probed

County will investigate State Farm General after complaints from victims. **BUSINESS, A10**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.

